

# **Professional Practices in IT**

## **Assignment Number 1**

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### **Abridged Version of the Story**

The Social Network narrates the story of the creation of Facebook which is one of the most influential social media sites in the present time. The main character of the film is Mark Zuckerberg who is a socially awkward but brilliant Harvard undergraduate student and has a passion for coding and innovation. He created a website called FaceMash which rated the attractiveness of students by allowing the users to compare student's photos side-by-side. As the website gained popularity among the students, controversies started spreading and Harvard's network crashed which captured the attention of Harvard's student body and Zuckerberg got into trouble with the administration. This initial dispute led Zuckerberg to build something bigger.

Due to this defame, Zuckerberg caught the attention of two fellow students, the Winklevoss twins who are working on a social networking idea and they approach Zuckerberg to bring their idea to real life. While Zuckerberg initially agrees to work on their told project but quickly, he develops a different network for social networking it was a website exclusive to Harvard students where users can share their profiles, photos and interests with one another. Zuckerberg also enlists the help of his friend Eduardo Saverin who provides the initial funding for this project. Together they built The Facebook which rapidly gained popularity among the students and soon expanded to other Ivy League schools.

As the platform grew, Zuckerberg's ambitions started to grow bigger, and he begins to seek additional investment to take The Facebook to the next level. He catches the attention of Sean Parker who is the co-founder of Napster, he advises Zuckerberg on how to turn The Facebook into a global brand. Parker's influence led to Zuckerberg moving to California, this started a fight between him and Saverin, who remains on the East Coast. The friendship slowly starts to deteriorate as Saverin's role in the company diminishes and he becomes increasingly marginalized. In California, Zuckerberg receives major investments which transform Facebook into a tech giant from a small college platform, attracting millions of users worldwide.

At the same time, Zuckerberg faces lawsuits from both the Winklevoss twins who say that Zuckerberg stole their idea and from Saverin who claims he was unfairly removed from the company. These law fights reveal a ruthless side of Zuckerberg's ambition as he struggles between his loyalty to Facebook's growth and the personal conflicts stemming from his actions. The story ends with Zuckerberg alone who is refreshing the Facebook profile of a former girlfriend which is a reminder of the personal costs of his journey to success.

## **Skills with Significant Contribution**

Several skills from the World Economic Forum's top 10 list played a pivotal role in the story:

### **Analytical Thinking**

Zuckerberg was very good at solving complex problems. When creating Facebook, he just didn't focus on writing the code, he also analyzed what people wanted from a social platform. He found different ways to make connecting online easier and faster. For example, he figured out how to organize user's profiles, friend lists and other features in a way that was easy for everyone to use.

Mark also designed algorithms which helped Facebook run smoothly even as the number of users grew, meaning as more people joined Facebook it didn't slow down or crash. His strong analytical skills helped him find solutions where others might see only challenges. He could see how small changes in the problems of the design could lead to a better experience for users, which made Facebook more successful.

### **Creative Thinking**

The idea of Facebook itself was a result of creative thinking. Mark noticed that there was a gap in the way people connected online and saw it as an opportunity to create something new. He just didn't want to make another website where people could post pictures, he wanted to build something where users could post different parts of their lives, like relationship statuses, updates about their day and photos with friends. This changed the way people thought about socializing on the internet.

Mark's creativity also came through with him introducing new features such as News Feed which allowed users to see what was happening in their friend's lives at a glance. He imagined ways to make Facebook feel more personal and interactive, which made it different from other websites at the time.

## **Technological Literacy**

Mark's skill with technology was a big reason why Facebook could be built in the first place. He was a highly skilled coder meaning he knew how he could make the computer to follow his instructions to make Facebook a reality. In the early days Mark wrote most of the code for Facebook himself, building features like user profiles, friend lists and messaging.

Without all this knowledge Mark couldn't have created such a highly complex platform as Facebook. His technological literacy allowed him to understand what was possible and what was not, and it helped him to build a website that was both innovative and efficient. This made it easier to add new features as Facebook grew.

## **Resilience, Flexibility, and Agility**

Building Facebook wasn't a piece of cake and Mark faced many challenges along the way. He had disputed between his friends and co-founders, legal battles with people who claimed he stole their idea, and a lot of pressure from the investors and users. But still, Mark stayed focused on his goal of making Facebook successful.

This required resilience ( the ability to keep going despite challenges ) and flexibility ( the ability to adapt to new situations ). For example, when he needed to expand Facebook quickly to keep up with its popularity, he found new investors and people to help him. Also, when he faced conflicts with co-founders, he adjusted his approach to keep Facebook growing.

Mark's ability to stay strong, make quick decisions and adapt to new challenges was crucial to Facebook's growth. This allowed him to take advantage of the opportunities and solve problems as they arose, making Facebook more successful than he had originally imagined.

## **Practical Advice for Developing These Skills**

To develop essential skills such as analytical thinking, creative thinking, technological literacy and resilience the following activities and exercises are recommended. These activities are designed to enhance the abilities needed for future success and align with the key skills demonstrated by Mark Zuckerberg in *The Social Network*.

## **Analytical Thinking**

### **Activity**

Engage in complex problem-solving through data analysis or logic-based puzzles. Participate in coding challenges such as on platforms like Kaggle where students can analyze datasets, this is highly recommended. Such challenges encourage students to draw insights from data and propose solutions to complex problems.

### **Exercise**

To build analytical thinking students can practice by breaking down real-world problems. For example, analyze trends in social media or examine market patterns and then propose data-based solutions. Also, regular engagement in logical reasoning activities such as solving chess or working on mathematical puzzles can strengthen analytical skills.

## **Creative Thinking**

### **Activity**

Organize regular brainstorming sessions where students work together to solve everyday problems in innovative ways. For example, students can redesign an existing app or create a new feature for a website. Engagement in creative hobbies like writing, painting or design-thinking workshops will also promote out-of-the-box thinking.

### **Exercise**

**Idea sprints** are a recommended exercise, in which students are given a short time to come up with unique solutions to a given problem. They can practice challenging assumptions such as **What if** scenarios to improve their creative thinking skills. This approach encourages open-mindedness and unconventional problem-solving making sure that the students think of what potential problems could occur if they were not to implement the feature or implement a feature in a particular way.

## **Technological Literacy**

### **Activity**

Encourage students to participate in coding boot camps or take online courses on platforms like Coursera or edX to build their technical skills. Hands-on coding projects

such as creating simple websites, applications, or AI models will provide practical experience with technology.

### **Exercise**

To deepen technological literacy, students can work on a tech-focused project where they build a small application or functional website using languages like Python or JavaScript. This exercise will help in enhancing their coding abilities and understanding of technical ecosystems which in turn will prepare them for various challenges in their upcoming tech field.

## **Resilience, Flexibility, and Agility**

### **Activity**

To make students feel real-world challenges group activities can be organized, where the students will work with tight deadlines and adapt to unexpected changes. This will help students develop quick decision-making and adaptability, which are essential in dynamic environments.

### **Exercise**

Mindfulness activities such as yoga, meditation or regular journaling can effectively build emotional resilience. For example, students can use journaling to see upon recent challenges, such as preparing for a presentation. The student can start by noting down their initial anxieties, the steps he took to prepare and lastly the strategies that helped him stay calm. This reflection allows students to recognize their progress, develop self-awareness and understand their strengths making it easier for them to adapt and stay resilient and confident in future situations.